Driving Platform Adoption with Embedded SREs

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Story time

Platform Engineering Challenge

Adoption

(& Alignment)

SRE is a more established practice

- 20 years since Google coined the term and published the books
- No stakeholder will doubt the role of reliability

Proactive reliability struggles

- SRE teams are usually small, very efficient
- But often lack the resources to do large-scale proactive initiatives
- Stuck on fire fighting mode too often

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Reliability Advocate

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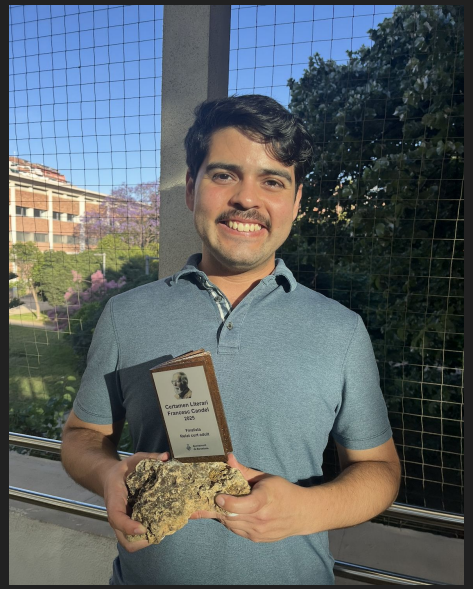

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Senior Platform Engineer

Chainalysis

10K Medalist

Setting the Scene - Out of the Box

- We don’t have a dedicated SRE team at Chainalysis.
- We have a central Platform team and a number of embedded devops engineers
- We provide O11y, and a base for reliability, out of the box - for new services.

What about the Older, Bigger, (more scary?) services...

- Retrofitting the golden path isn't easy
- Self-Service isn't an option

Why older services hesitate...

- The perceived risk can be too high
- The perceived investment can seem too expensive
  - *especially when teams are focused on keeping their customers happy*
- The tech-debt mountain may just look too high to climb

What's a Platform team to do?

🥷 Send in the Platform-Team

We thought we'd learn from our SRE colleagues

We sent some Platform Engineers to select teams - SRE embedded-style, for a time-limited mission

Can Platform learn from SREs?

- Overview the relationship between SRE and Platform Engineering
- How we trailed an embedded Platform SRE program
- What we learned on each iteration of the program
- What does the road ahead look like?

1: Picked the Easy Services

- We made it easy for ourselves.
- We got great results. Easy to migrate.
- Effective, but didn’t prepare us for what really delivers value

2: Taught by Example

The Platform team were Driving

We delivered;

- Guided migrations
- Demonstrations of moving closer towards alignment
- Guides for self-service

2: Taught by Example

The Platform team were Driving

We got;

- Low attendance
- Limited Engagement
- Frustration (for everyone)

3: Taught a Team to Fish

Give someone a fish and you feed them for a day;

Teach someone to fish and you feed them for a lifetime.

… at least that was the plan.

We:

1. Handed over the keys to the Feature teams
2. Let the Feature teams drive

3: Taught a Team to Fish

We got;

1. Higher engagement
2. More involvement
3. Less frustration

4. Single Point of Ownership

- Exceptional performance. Biggest impact.

    Even though engagement was great and people were learning, the migration progress was going very slow and driven exclusively by us and our mob sessions.

- Accountability was key to drive service migrations.

5. Senior leaders (active) Sponsorship

So Where are We Now?

- We’re in the middle.

- Teams are migrating their services to the managed platform - with a varying levels of support from Platform

But this is just the beginning

We’re still learning

- We thought that all teams just needed to learn `how to fish`
- Lessons didn’t always translate between teams

💡 Maybe this is a human challenge not a technical one?

What we learned?

There isn't a Silver Bullet - one size doesn't fit all

We need to approach it as engineers.

- Agile & Iterative. If something doesn't work, move on to the next.

At best, aim to have

- A set of approaches to use.

We need everybody to want the same thing

What did work?

- Having a strong Platform presence
- Time limited well-scoped engagement with application teams
- Single Owner
- Active & Visible Senior Leadership Sponsorship

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